

The Market of Mixed-Up Magic

The Floating Isles are islands adrift in a calm sky, in a realm where magic only ever helps: it grows, it heals, it changes one thing into another, and it lets you speak with animals and objects. It never harms. On the home island, the House of the Little Mages sits at the highest point, where young mages learn their first spells, and the city where the families live spreads below. Inside the school grounds lies the Great Garden, the green heart of the whole island. Here nobody loses; you find your way by being kind and full of ideas.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.

★ *Read aloud, or let an older child read. Stop often to let everyone share their ideas. There are no wrong answers here, only new ones to try.*

Before you begin

It is market day on the home island. The Market Row is bright and busy. Every stall is full: warm bread, ripe fruit, neat shoes, and bright toys.

Then there is a small flash and a soft pop. All at once, everything is in the wrong place. The baker is holding a pair of boots. The cobbler is holding a kite. The fruit and the toys have swapped stalls. Nobody can find their things.

You are little mages, and you can put this right. "Let us untangle the market," you say together.

★ *What is your mage name? Which magic do you choose: Light, Grow, Change, or Voice?*

Stop 1 The Muddled Stalls

You walk along the row. Every object sits in the wrong place, looking a little lost. A pair of boots blinks up at you from the bread stall.

The Mist Cat pads over and sits beside you, ready to help.

★ *How can you find out where everything belongs? Could you ask the objects themselves? Try something and see.*

When the objects tell you their homes, you start carrying them back. The easy ones are soon in the right place again. But a few are still in a muddle.

Stop 2 The Memory of the Market

To finish, you need to remember how the market looked before the mix-up: who had what, and where. That is hard, because everything has moved.

A Talking Flower in a pot leans close and hums the market in order, stall by stall, to help you remember.

★ *Can you remember which stall had the bread, the fruit, the shoes and the toys? Match each thing back to the right stall.*

When you set each thing where it began, more of the market is happy again. Only one tangle is left, and it is a tricky one.

Stop 3 The Last Swap

Three stalls are still wrong, and they are tangled in a loop. The baker has boots. The cobbler has a kite. The toymaker has bread. Each one is holding the wrong thing, and to fix it you must work out who should pass what to whom.



Who gives their thing to whom, so that everyone ends up with the right one? Talk it through together.

When you untangle the last swap, the whole Market Row cheers. Every stall is right again. But where did the mix-up come from in the first place?

Pip the New Mage

Behind a quiet stall you find a young mage curled up small. Their name is Pip, and it is their very first day. Pip tried a Change spell to help, but it went wonky and muddled the whole market. Pip was so worried, and so shy, that they hid away.

There is no telling-off here. Everyone makes mistakes, especially on a first day.



What do you say to Pip? How can you show them that it is alright, and that nobody fixed this alone, you fixed it together?

When you tell Pip kindly that all is well, they peek out and smile. With one careful Change, Pip sets the very last thing right, and the whole market claps. Pip stands a little taller.

You did it together. You were kind, and you were full of ideas. Well done.

The Market of Mixed-Up Magic: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which on the Isles means a few small jobs at once: narrator, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses.

Setting up

- You do not need a printed map for this one. Picture the Market Row, or lay out a few household objects to be the stalls and their goods.
- Each player chooses one magic: Light, Grow, Change, or Voice. Two different magics work best, because combining them is half the fun. (Voice is especially handy here, but every magic has a place.)
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). These are spent and refilled during play.
- Build the muddled goods (a loaf, a pair of boots, a kite, some fruit) from household bits and bricks, so the children can move them about. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Instead each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**. When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge in this story can be played with a single ordinary die, and richer dice sets simply make it feel grander.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to try the same idea again, or
- **Combine two magics** once per stop to pass the challenge with no roll at all (Voice and Light, say, or Change and Grow, working as one).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. So nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed. Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. The lesson underneath the whole game is that you get further together.

The surprise

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a surprise and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for surprises; with a single ordinary die, read the line that matches the number rolled.

Roll	Surprise
1	A Messenger Butterfly flutters past and gives you one free hint.
2	A kind stallholder hands you a snack: take back one energy star.
3	A tidy little gust of wind: the next challenge is Easy.
4	The Mist Cat appears and purrs. All is well; carry on.
5	You spot a helpful label nobody noticed: keep one roll to use again later.
6	A street musician strikes up a tune and everyone hums along for one happy turn.

How it ends

The market is not put right by catching anyone out. The muddle was made by Pip, a kind apprentice mage on their first day, whose Change spell slipped and who was too shy to admit it. The adventure is won when the children reassure Pip, show that mistakes are mended together, and give them the courage to set the last thing right. Let that land gently; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for how to play the ending, and for the solutions to the three stops.

The Market of Mixed-Up Magic: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward good ideas and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Muddled Stalls (Easy)

The challenge. Every object has jumped to the wrong stall. The players need a way to discover where each thing truly belongs.

Intended solutions. Any of the magics can help:

- **Voice** is the natural fit: ask each object where its home is, and it will happily tell you (the boots want the cobbler, the bread wants the baker, and so on).
- **Light** reveals a faint matching mark or colour that pairs each object to its stall.
- **Change** can mend a torn label so a stall can be read again.

Fallback. If a roll misses, the Mist Cat picks up one object in its mouth and carries it pointedly to the right stall, showing the children how, then they spend an energy star or combine two magics to finish the easy ones. Nobody is stuck for long.

Stop 2: The Memory of the Market (Normal)

The challenge. To return the rest, the players must remember the market as it was: which goods belonged at which stall.

Solution. This is a **memory** moment. The four pairings are:

- bread goes to the **baker**
- fruit goes to the **greengrocer**
- shoes go to the **cobbler**
- toys go to the **toymaker**

The Talking Flower hums the stalls in order to help. Let the children recall and place each pairing. Working it out with the flower's help still counts as a full success.

Fallback. If they freeze, have the Talking Flower sing the order slowly, one stall at a time, and let the players place one pairing per line. Getting there with a nudge tops up an energy star.

Stop 3: The Last Swap (Normal)

The challenge. Three stalls are tangled in a loop: the baker holds boots, the cobbler holds a kite, and the toymaker holds bread. The players must work out the passes that put everything right.

Solution. Each stall's own goods are: baker = bread, cobbler = shoes (boots), toymaker = toys (the kite). So it is a three-step ring:

- the **baker** passes the boots to the **cobbler**,
- the **cobbler** passes the kite to the **toymaker**,
- the **toymaker** passes the bread to the **baker**.

Then everyone holds their own. Lay out three objects and three stalls so the children can physically move them; the logic clicks once they see it as a ring.

Fallback. If they are stuck, the Mist Cat nudges the boots toward the cobbler to start the chain ("boots belong with shoes"), and the rest tends to follow. Solving it with one nudge is a full success.

Pip the New Mage (no roll)

This is the resolution, not a puzzle, so there is no band and no roll. Behind a stall the players find **Pip**, a kind apprentice mage on their very first day, whose Change spell slipped and muddled the market, and who hid away out of worry and shyness.

Play it softly. Let the children decide how to reach out: a kind word, a reminder that everyone makes mistakes, an offer to stand beside Pip while they try again. There is no scolding and no trick. When the children reassure Pip, Pip finds the courage to set the last thing right with a careful Change, and the market cheers. End on that warmth. The children have won by being kind and full of ideas, which is the only way anyone wins on the Isles.

Wander and Tales

Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.